



Flourishing start: Jesse Marsch, who is American, has captured the hearts of many Canadians since he took the job in May 2024 and guided the team to the semifinals of the Copa América. AFP

Americans played just their second World Cup in 2022 but came back empty-handed. They were ranked 38th when they entered the tournament but plunged to 58th in the aftermath of three group-stage defeats.

The appointment of Jesse Marsch transformed the mood. The American guided Canada to the Copa America semifinals in 2024, where the team received a valuable education against world champion Argentina. A 2-0 defeat was hardly disastrous, and Canada still found a way into the last four.

Another 2-0 loss to Argentina followed in the semifinal before Canada narrowly missed out on third place after a penalty shootout defeat to Uruguay. The campaign was considerably more impressive than that of long-time rival USA, which exited in the group stage.

Canada boasts several players operating in Europe's top leagues, none more prominent than Bayern Munich's Alphonso Davies, who faces a race against time to prove his fitness. Jonathan David, Tajon Buchanan and Cyle Larin provide further quality and could flourish, particularly with home support behind them.

Then there is Bosnia and Herzegovina, which qualified at the expense of multi-time former champion Italy and will feel it can bring down any team on its day.

ON THE RADAR



Breel Embolo (Switzerland)

At 29, Embolo is probably at the peak of his powers. His 11 goal contributions for Sassuolo this season were perhaps underwhelming. But he has the experience of playing at the World Cup and can convert chances.



Jonathan David (Canada)

David has the exposure of big games, having played for Juventus. He captains the side in Davies' absence and will be on penalty duty too. He is versatile and can play just as effectively behind another striker as he can as the number nine.